DAVID J. NAJERA

ENTERPRISE TRANSFORMATION EXECUTIVE | STRATEGY • PEOPLE • EXECUTION
Misawa, Japan | +81-80-5552-0928 | davidnajera73@gmail.com | linkedin.com/in/david-j-najera

EXECUTIVE PROFILE

Enterprise transformation executive with 29 years of global leadership solving complex organizational problems across operations, technology, human capital, infrastructure, and multinational environments. Trusted by senior executives to diagnose barriers to execution, align competing stakeholders, redesign operating models, and turn strategy into measurable results. Known for entering high-consequence environments where priorities, people, processes, and resources are not fully aligned—and building the leadership systems, governance structures, and organizational discipline required to move from ambiguity to execution. Career impact spans organizations and communities of up to 13,000 people, billion-dollar portfolios, multinational partnerships, and enterprise transformations involving thousands of personnel.

CORE VALUE PROPOSITION

STRATEGY: Diagnose Complex Problems • Translate Ambiguity into Priorities • Executive Advisory • Operating Model Design • Resource Allocation | PEOPLE: Stakeholder Alignment • Leadership Development • Talent & Succession • Change Leadership • Accountability | EXECUTION: Governance • Cross-Functional Transformation • Operational Excellence • Risk Management • Measurable Outcomes

Leadership approach: Diagnose the problem → Align the people → Build the system → Drive execution

SIGNATURE LEADERSHIP IMPACT

- Built and institutionalized a wing-wide governance model that brought command teams and cross-service stakeholders into one decision framework, reducing organizational friction and accelerating strategic execution during a major fighter-wing transition.
- Directed exercises and readiness training that prepared 3,000 personnel for combat operations, then shaped deployment and sustainment decisions that moved the force from notification to ready-to-depart in three days and enabled immediate support to initial combat operations - the wing's first major deployment in 14 years.
- Built a standardized onboarding and development program for newly selected senior leaders, mobilizing 300+ experienced leaders as mentors and instructors and establishing a structured curriculum linking leadership development to Indo-Pacific and organizational priorities.
- Advised executive leadership on F-35 transformation across an 11,000-person installation, correcting critical maintenance workforce gaps with headquarters and establishing cross-agency governance to align infrastructure, contractor, healthcare, education, and community requirements and resolve transition risks.
- Redesigned the organizational operating model supporting the establishment of the U.S. Space Force by reducing staffing requirements 33% while maintaining full mission capability.
- Reprioritized installation support across a 13,000-person community and a $71M O&M/NAF/MWR budget, driving corrective action on infrastructure, contingency readiness, quality of life, and community programs while increasing MWR revenue $1.5M annually.

- Redesigned technology-enabled workflows and administrative processes across 20 global sites, replacing fragmented manual processes with standardized digital solutions that improved operational efficiency by 30–40%.
- Built workforce-development and accountability systems affecting approximately 10,000 personnel across East and Southwest Asia, linking leadership development, quality assurance, performance management, and readiness.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Command Chief / Senior Executive Advisor, 35th Fighter Wing

U.S. Air Force | Misawa Air Base, Japan | 2024-Present

Principal advisor to the Wing Commander for a fighter wing of more than 6,000 personnel and an 11,000-person installation supporting F-16, F-35, and P-8 operations, six U.S. military branches, and bilateral Japanese partners.

- Partnered with executive leadership to shape strategic vision and priorities for a 6,000+ person organization, aligning senior operational and functional leaders to drive organization-wide execution while sustaining six major exercises and seven deployments.
- Directed exercises and readiness training that prepared 3,000 personnel for combat operations, then shaped deployment and sustainment decisions that moved the force from notification to ready-to-depart in three days and enabled immediate support to initial combat operations - the wing's first major deployment in 14 years.
- Built a standardized onboarding and development program for newly selected senior leaders, mobilizing 300+ experienced leaders as mentors and instructors and establishing a structured curriculum linking leadership development to Indo-Pacific and organizational priorities.
- Advised executive leadership on F-35 transformation across an 11,000-person installation, correcting critical maintenance workforce gaps with headquarters and establishing cross-agency governance to align infrastructure, contractor, healthcare, education, and community requirements and resolve transition risks.
- Facilitated a first-of-its-kind multinational interoperability exercise, aligning the Japan Air Self-Defense Force (JASDF) and visiting organizations to enable cross-national teams to work on one another’s aircraft and share equipment and personnel, demonstrating the ability to integrate resources across allied forces in conflict and peacetime operations.

Operations Director, Cyber & Talent Development

U.S. Air Force, 100th Communications Squadron | RAF Mildenhall, United Kingdom | 2023-2024

Senior operations and workforce leader for a 300-person cyber and information organization supporting approximately 3,900 personnel and geographically dispersed European operations.

- Secured executive approval for a classified network modernization to strengthen security and operational capability; identified a project-information leak and postponed implementation to mitigate risk while supporting active regional operations.
- Championed adoption of new agile cyber capabilities, allocating personnel, funding, and training to test prototype equipment across ~12 European sites and validate operational value and risk for broader implementation.
- Integrated network defense, information assurance, technology investment, physical security, and workforce readiness into a common operating approach, enabling leaders to assess cyber risk, capability gaps, and investment priorities as enterprise decisions rather than isolated technical issues.

- Aligned and developed a 300-person cyber and information workforce around operational requirements, establishing remote classified data-processing capabilities that enabled transient deployed forces to securely access mission-critical information while operating away from established infrastructure.

Senior Enlisted Leader / Executive Operations Director (Deputy Mayor / Town Manager Equivalent)

U.S. Air Force, 51st Mission Support Group | Osan Air Base, Republic of Korea | 2021-2023

Senior advisor to a 2,700-person mission support group spanning five squadrons on a joint U.S.-Korean installation of 13,000 personnel. Oversaw enterprise support encompassing 1,100 facilities, three runways, 37 dormitories, a $127M war-reserve materiel stockpile, $18B in protected resources, and a $71M O&M/NAF/MWR budget while integrating infrastructure, emergency operations, public services, personnel support, and operational readiness.

- Integrated competing requirements across 35 organizations into an installation-wide prioritization process, balancing infrastructure, workforce, emergency-response, public-service, and operational needs to direct finite resources toward the highest mission and quality-of-life priorities for a 13,000-person community.
- Coordinated crisis response during a major power outage, relocating 150 residents and establishing an emergency center during extreme heat; returned families to their homes within 48 hours and prioritized $24M in infrastructure requirements to address recurring failures.
- Coordinated installation support for a 450-person joint exercise and four base-wide contingency exercises enabling 8,000 sorties, integrating logistics, infrastructure, emergency response, and support functions to prove combat and sustainment capability in response to adversary aggression.
- Synchronized installation support for three presidential directives providing munitions to Ukraine in preparation for upcoming operations, aligning logistics, infrastructure, personnel, and operational requirements to execute time-sensitive national-defense priorities.
- Executed 7th Air Force's first Agile Combat Employment dispersal, integrating peninsula-wide logistics, communications, and support procedures to demonstrate simultaneous combat operations from two locations with zero mission degradation.
- Integrated four counter-UAS defense capabilities with installation security and command-and-control systems in response to seven unmanned-aircraft incursions, strengthening protection of 13,000 personnel and $1.5B in critical assets.
- Redesigned quality-of-life programming and external partnerships, generating $1.5M in additional annual revenue while strengthening community services for a 13,000-person installation.
- Identified gaps in noncombatant-evacuation accountability and developed joint USFK procedures that established the standard for Air Force organizations across the Korean Peninsula, improving personnel and family accountability during contingency operations.
- Secured $1M to replace failed HVAC infrastructure at the installation's primary dining facility serving junior enlisted personnel, restoring a critical service supporting approximately 7,000 Airmen.
- Integrated installation support for a forward-deployed 5,600-person fighter wing across five wartime exercises, aligning logistics, infrastructure, personnel, and support functions to sustain combat operations under contested contingency conditions.

- Designed and facilitated an eight-week leadership-development program for 98 emerging leaders, combining mentoring, cross-functional development, and structured preparation for advancement into higher-level leadership positions.
- Brokered agreements with Korean civil authorities during pandemic restrictions that preserved U.S. military access to local communities, businesses, and services, supporting workforce morale and local economic activity while strengthening U.S.-Korean civic relationships; became the first enlisted U.S. service member awarded Honorary Republic of Korea citizenship.

Chief Operations Superintendent, Mobility & Joint Operations Support

U.S. Air Force | Fort Bragg, North Carolina | 2020-2021

Senior leader integrating Air Force and Army organizations supporting global special-operations quick-reaction forces, air mobility, logistics, and rapid deployment.

- Integrated Air Force and Army logistics processes supporting global special-operations quick-reaction forces, aligning cargo, aircraft load planning, transportation, personnel, and secure-movement requirements to preserve rapid deployment capability across organizational boundaries.
- Directed rapid-response logistics supporting national-defense contingencies while personally validating aircraft load plans and secure cargo movement, enabling deployment of 2,500 personnel and 36 tons of mission-essential equipment to contested environments.
- Relocated mission-critical operations to a neighboring installation during complete flightline resurfacing and fiber-network modernization, developing transportation and operating plans that sustained uninterrupted rapid-response and training capabilities throughout the transition.
- Designed 24/7 staffing, quarantine, and continuity procedures during COVID-19 workforce restrictions, sustaining uninterrupted movement of mission-critical cargo and personnel supporting global rapid-response operations.

Chief, Space & Cyber Operations

U.S. Air Force | Vandenberg Air Force Base, California | 2017-2020

Senior operations leader responsible for cyber, space launch, workforce, and joint-service support across nationally significant launch, experimental, and defense missions.

- Directed a 100-person cyber and space workforce protecting $25B in national-defense assets, identifying and correcting vulnerabilities across interconnected satellite and ground-control operations while sustaining uninterrupted launch and range execution.
- Redesigned the organizational operating model supporting the establishment of the U.S. Space Force by reducing staffing requirements 33% while maintaining full mission capability.
- Prioritized a $1.8M operating budget and joint-service workforce across geographically dispersed locations supporting 2,500 personnel, directing constrained resources toward the highest-risk space-launch, cyber, and mission-support requirements to enable 20 space-asset launches.

First Sergeant / Senior Human Capital & Organizational Leadership Advisor

U.S. Air Force | Japan, Qatar and other global locations | 2011-2017 | 6.5 years

Served 6.5 years as a First Sergeant and senior advisor to commanders on workforce readiness, employee well-being, discipline, performance, professional development, recognition, organizational climate, and complex personnel issues across operational organizations in East and Southwest Asia.

- Diagnosed complex workforce, discipline, performance, and organizational-climate problems across aerial port, logistics, medical, and maintenance organizations, translating root causes into commander decisions and targeted interventions that restored or sustained high-performing operations and mission readiness.
- Built leadership-development, mentoring, recognition, and accountability systems that translated organizational priorities into workforce expectations, developing emerging leaders while reinforcing performance and discipline across diverse operational teams.
- Managed complex personnel crises during deployed operations, coordinating emergency return of two members facing critical circumstances at their home stations while rebalancing staffing and responsibilities to preserve operational continuity.
- Conducted two sensitive investigations involving sexual-assault allegations, safeguarding the rights and welfare of both reporting parties and accused members while ensuring impartial fact-finding, appropriate command action, and continued mission effectiveness.
- Coordinated commanders, medical, legal, housing, community, and employee-support organizations to resolve complex workforce and family crises across Japan, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, and U.S. organizations, creating integrated solutions when individual cases crossed organizational, cultural, and jurisdictional boundaries.

Information Management, Technology & Administrative Operations Leadership

U.S. Air Force | United States, United Kingdom, South Korea, Saudi Arabia and other global locations | 1997-2011

Progressed from front-line information management and customer support into supervisory, technology, knowledge-management, workflow-transformation, administrative-operations, and enterprise program leadership roles, including data and information lifecycle management, requirements analysis, collaboration, dashboards, and delivery of decision-quality information to senior leaders.

- Transformed workflows and digital processes across an $8B global IT portfolio spanning 20 sites, improving operational efficiency by up to 40% while strengthening reliability and mission support.

SELECTED TRANSFORMATION PORTFOLIO

- Enterprise Governance: Built cross-functional decision structures that aligned executive teams and stakeholders around shared priorities, resource tradeoffs, and faster execution.
- F-35 Integration: Aligned manpower, infrastructure, contractor, healthcare, education, and community requirements for a major fighter transition affecting an 11,000-person installation while sustaining existing operations.
- Operation EPIC FURY: Prepared and synchronized 3,000 personnel for the wing's first major deployment in 14 years, moving from notification to ready-to-depart in three days and enabling immediate combat support.
- Space Force Organizational Design: Redesigned staffing and operating structures for an emerging service, reducing requirements 33% while maintaining full mission capability.
- Cyber & Digital Modernization: Converted cyber risk into executive investment decisions, field-tested agile capabilities across ~12 European sites, and established remote classified processing for deployed forces.
- Municipal-Scale Operations: Integrated infrastructure, emergency response, workforce, and community-service priorities across 35 organizations supporting a 13,000-person installation.

- Talent & Succession Strategy: Built mentoring, leadership-development, recognition, and accountability systems that prepared emerging leaders for greater responsibility and reinforced organizational performance.
- International Partnership: Brokered cross-cultural agreements and facilitated first-of-its-kind allied interoperability, strengthening U.S.-Japan and U.S.-Korean military and civic partnerships.

EXECUTIVE COMMUNICATIONS & ADVISORY

- Diagnose complex workforce, technology, infrastructure, readiness, and operational problems, identify underlying causes, and translate them into executive-level choices, tradeoffs, and actionable solutions.
- Build alignment among leaders with competing priorities by framing decisions around enterprise outcomes, resource constraints, organizational risk, and measurable operational impact.
- Synthesize complex operational, workforce, resource, and organizational information into executive briefings, strategic plans, decision analyses, and policy recommendations that enable senior leaders to make informed decisions and drive execution.
- Navigate high-stakes, high-discretion environments by rapidly synthesizing incomplete information, exercising cross-cultural judgment, and translating complex issues for technical and nontechnical stakeholders.

PUBLICATIONS & THOUGHT LEADERSHIP

The Cost of Presence: Leadership Forged Through Trial, Faith, and Responsibility - Author, 2026

The Adventures of the Najera Sisters: A Journey Remembered - Author, 2026

“Caring for our Airmen in Times of Tragedy” - U.S. Air Force Commentary, 2012

EDUCATION

M.S., Business Management - Western Governors University, 2025 | B.S., General Studies - University of Management & Technology, 2015 | A.A.S., Human Resources Management - Community College of the Air Force, 2012 | A.A.S., Information Management - Community College of the Air Force, 2001

CERTIFICATIONS

Professional Management Certification | CompTIA Security+ | CompTIA A+ | DoD/DEOMI Mediation Certification | Military Sherpa Coach | Grief Recovery Method Specialist

EXECUTIVE & PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

Chief Master Sergeant Leadership Course, Air University - Enterprise Leadership, National Security & Strategic Decision-Making | Senior Enlisted Advanced Course - Strategic Leadership, Critical Thinking & Warfighting | Cyberspace 300, AFIT - Joint Cyber Operations, Vulnerability Analysis & Risk-Based Decision-Making | AFFOR Intermediate Staff Course - Operational Strategy, Joint Planning & Global Force Management | USAF First Sergeant Academy - Human Capital Management, Employee Relations & Organizational Readiness | Defense Security Assistance Management Course

SELECTED RECOGNITION

- First enlisted U.S. service member awarded Honorary Republic of Korea Citizenship for strengthening U.S.-Korean governmental, military, civic, and community relationships.
- Japan Air Self-Defense Force (JASDF) Letter of Appreciation - Recognized for strengthening U.S.-Japan relationships and advancing bilateral military integration and cooperation.

PROFESSIONAL & COMMUNITY AFFILIATIONS

Air Force Sergeants Association (AFSA) - Lifetime Member | Veterans of Foreign Wars (VFW) - Lifetime Member | Air & Space Forces Association (AFA) - Member | Misawa International Club - Invited Member

GLOBAL & FUNCTIONAL EXPERIENCE

Japan • Republic of Korea • United Kingdom • Qatar • Saudi Arabia • United States • Indo-Pacific • Europe • Middle East | Aviation Operations • Global Mobility • Special Operations Support • Space & Launch Operations • Cyber & Information Operations • Human Capital • Executive Coaching & Mentoring • Municipal-Scale Operations • Infrastructure & Facilities • Emergency & Crisis Management • Community Services • Executive Events & Community Engagement • Logistics & Supply Chain • Executive Governance • Multinational & Cross-Cultural Partnerships